

Have you ever tried swapping your wife/husband or girlfriend/boyfriend?

YES 20

NO 75

Have thought about it 5

Male 19, Female 27

Male 77, Female 61

Male 4, Female 12

All figures in per cent

Of the females who have committed adultery, 27 per cent of those interviewed said they were engaged in swapping partners, with the highest incidence in Bangalore (58 per cent) and Patna (57 per cent).

ships, sexual or otherwise intimate. Despite the paucity of data, long-standing literary traditions of same-sex love in India make it seem likely that structures of compulsory heterosexuality (and reproduction) hid other affective or physical relations. Did such same-sex bonds constitute adultery since they did not pose a threat to the "legitimacy" of offspring? Would the same-sex relationships of married people now meet the other definition of adultery as a transgression of conjugal exclusivity?

The Hindu Marriage Act 1955 established monogamy as a radically different norm of modernity imagined for the new post-colonial subject. Historians have suggested that new ways of thinking may have come earlier, in late 19th and early 20th century discourses which saw marriage in terms of compatibility and companionship, connected to a robust nationalism. The Act may have reflected such norms in the ways in which it assumes equality in marital relations, but non-Hindu women were left behind in that legislative moment. Muslim polygyny continued to be the law, with scant protections for first wives to have a say in subsequent marriages (as Bangladesh mandates). Until recently, Christian marriage law required women seeking divorce to prove adultery as well as an additional ground such as neglect or cruelty.

The 2008 INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG sex survey figures indicate that cultural norms around monogamy may be more fluid than the legal standard. Eight per cent women and 43 per cent men reported approval of adultery, 8 per cent women and 41 per cent men reported committing adultery (27 per cent and 19 per cent of whom respectively reported swapping partners). Three per cent married men reported "having sex with a blood relation", 16 per cent married men reported having had a homosexual relationship, 18 per cent married men reported "having sex with a eunuch," and 21 per cent married men reported visiting sex workers (54 per cent of whom reported paying for it "all the time" or "sometimes"). The corresponding numbers for married women are 1 per cent, 6 per cent, 6 per cent and 2 per cent (51 per cent) respectively. It is unclear whether incest, same-sex relationships or paid sex constitute adultery for these people within the time frame of the marriage.

These survey figures need not, however, indicate a rising trend of adultery; they may just as well signal that conjugal exclusivity has not become, or has never been, the singular mode of